maintaining its operational focus. Despite the strain, the WHO continued to work toward its mission, demonstrating resilience in the face of one of its most significant challenges.[64] However, Trump's actions left lasting stains on the institution, including reduced credibility and financial flexibility, illustrating the precarious position IOs face when confronted with populist opposition from key member states.

8.7 WTO and Trump

The WTO, originally established as the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade after World War II, has long been a cornerstone of international trade governance. Founded by the United States and its Western allies, the organization has historically enjoyed robust American support. Under the GATT/WTO framework, global trade has expanded dramatically, and tariff levels have plummeted, fueling economic growth and integration worldwide (Goldstein, Rivers, and Tomz 2007). Yet, the institution's trajectory shifted significantly with the arrival of Donald Trump in the White House in 2017. His administration mounted a sustained campaign against the WTO, marking a stark departure from decades of US advocacy for multilateral trade rules (Jones 2021).

The WTO embodies many of the features that populist leaders like Trump find objectionable. It is an elite-driven institution, staffed by a relatively small cadre of expert bureaucrats, international civil servants, and panels of adjudicators. Its mandate imposes far-reaching constraints on national sovereignty, requiring member states to abide by rules governing everything from intellectual-property rights and investment measures to anti-dumping policies and tariff schedules. Over time, successive rounds of negotiations have expanded both the scope and stringency of WTO regulations, amplifying its role as a global trade arbiter (Davis 2012). And unlike many organs of international law, the WTO is binding and can authorize costly retaliation against countries violating trade rules.

Trump's hostility toward the WTO was fueled in part by a series of adverse rulings issued by its dispute-settlement body against the United States. The administration accused the body of exceeding its mandate by interpreting trade law rather than adhering strictly to its text. These grievances dovetailed with broader populist concerns about sovereignty, as